



Spirit of **INDIA**
Youth Special

HOME RUN

THEIR goal isn't the dollar dream, supersize cars or a house with a white picket fence. For these young people, it was just as easy to chuck their Ivy League MBAs and white-collar jobs with a corner office as it was to follow their heart and return home to tread the uncommon path.

Whether it is the mechanical engineer from Detroit who returned to provide basic facilities to a little village in Tamil Nadu or the young agri-entrepreneur who always dreamed of going home with a foreign degree to transform agricultural methods in Kutch.

Just like the young man who turned south Gujarat into the rose hub of the country. And the electrical engineering student from the University of Cincinnati who refused to be merely a spectator to the devastation brought by the tsunami. For them western education is not an end in itself, it's the means to achieve the bigger goals in life, to bring change, to explore new possibilities and positively impact most lives. Their vision is to empower their country and for them, the phrase 'making a difference' is not a mere cliché. This is the youth that breaks the norm, ignores convention and knows that there is more to life than the glorious American dream.

"THE FARMERS OF INDIA JUST DON'T know the potential of land. Once they understand this, they will see it as gold."

KUMAR PATEL, ROSE FARMER, 34



CHINTAN MEHTA

The big Hurdle

Patel did the unthinkable by growing roses in a place where temperatures shoot up to 42°C. Rose farming needs a maximum of 25°C.

When Kumar Patel decided to try his hand at rose farming in 2003 on his family land of 75 acres in Kuched village in Navsari district, Gujarat, little did he imagine he would propel 65 such projects in 25 villages and provide employment to 3,000 people. It wasn't easy to grow roses in a place most unsuitable for rose farming. But Patel, a postgraduate in management from the San Francisco State University, got 10-year-old weather data for his region and sent it to a leading rose growing company abroad, which then designed greenhouses to fit local weather conditions. He used hydroponic technology, which meant putting rose plants in a tray and using a mix of crushed coir instead of soil. Right now, Patel

grows roses in 15-acre patch of land covered by greenhouses. Each acre yields annually around six lakh roses worth Rs 20-25 lakh. This year Patel exported roses worth Rs 5 crore. His target for next year is Rs 11 crore. Says Suresh Parmar, a rose farmer, "Kumar has laid out a new path at the end of which farmers see prosperity." Patel's experiment to prosperity involved an investment of Rs 40 lakh on every acre. But then every rose has its thorns.

by Uday Mahurkar

